Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Samuel Taylor Coleridge's "To the Autumnal Moon"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Coleridge's poem include

alliteration,
ambiguity,
analogy,
apostrophe,
assonance,
controlling image,
diction,
imagination,
iambic pentameter,
meter,
muse,
octave,
personification,
reification,
rhyme,
rhythm,
sestet,
sigmatism,
simile,
sonnet,
synaesthesia,
tenor,
tone,
vehicle,
visual imagery, and
volta.

The contestant has been asked to discuss the poet's comparison of hope to the moon.

The young writer should recognize the turn in thought (the volta) that begins the sonnet's sestet: "Ah, such is Hope! as changeful, and as fair!" (line 9). The ever-changing moon, the "Mother of wildly-working visions" (line 2) serves as the vehicle in the comparison that is the poem. Hope, changeful and fair (line 9), is the tenor. The student's comparison can dwell, and successfully so, on the visual imagery of both the moon as a "weak eye glimmer[ing] through a fleecy veil"—the clouds (line 4) and Hope's peering and "hid[ing] behind the dragon-winged Despair" (lines 10-11), as well as on Hope's emerging "o'er sorrow-clouded breast of Care" (line 13).

The student might opt to discuss the comparison in terms of reification, wherein Hope and Despair and Care, all abstractions, are treated as concrete objects in the persona's comparing Hope to the literal moon. The triumph of Hope (line 14) is described in astronomical terms that render the "mild splendor" (line 1) and the "placid lightning" (line 8) inferior (line 14) to the power ("like a meteor kindling in its flight") of the poet's imagination (by analogy, the "wildly-working visions")—a poetic imagination ultimately responsible for the comparison in the poem.

The optimism resonating in the poem's title (later to be immortalized in Shelley's "can Spring be far behind?") might engender some speculation regarding the poem's tone.